



How did counting begin?

When people first started counting, they almost certainly used their hands. Since most people have ten fingers to count with, it made sense to count in tens, and this is how our modern counting system (the decimal system) began.

Why use hands?

Fingers gave people a handy way of counting even before they had words for numbers. Touching fingers while you count helps you keep track, and by holding fingers in the air you can communicate numbers without needing words. The link between fingers and numbers is very ancient. Even today, we use the Latin word for finger (digit) to mean number.



What's base 10?

Mathematicians say we count in base ten, which means we count in groups of ten. There's no mathematical reason why we have to count in tens,

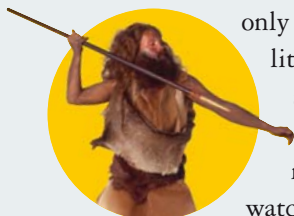
it's just an accident of biology. If aliens with only eight fingers exist, they probably count in base eight.



Did cavemen count?

For most of history, people actually had little need for numbers. Before farming was invented, people lived as "hunter-gatherers", collecting food from the wild. They gathered

only what they needed and had little left over to trade or hoard, so there wasn't much point in counting things. However, they may have had a sense of time by watching the Sun, Moon, and stars.



Members of the the Pirahã tribe in the Amazon rainforest don't count past two

